

religion **TEMPLE STAMPEDE**

DEATH TRAPS

Some of the recent major tragedies at places of worship



January 27, 2003

39 killed, 125 hurt in a stampede at the Nashik Kumbh Mela.

January 25, 2005

340 people trampled to death at Kalubai temple in Mandravedi, Maharashtra.

March 7, 2006

28 killed, 101 hurt in blasts at a temple and at the railway station in Varanasi.

September 6, 2007

11 killed, dozens hurt in a stampede outside an ashram in Bharra village in Jabalpur.

October 14, 2007

11 killed, 30 wounded at Mahakali temple in Panchmahal, Gujarat.

August 3, 2008

162 dead in a stampede triggered by rumours of a rockslide at Naina Devi temple in Himachal Pradesh.

other VIPs. Police officials now say that they opened a new pathway to shield women devotees from the raucous youth. Old-timers say that of late many young men had been arriving not so much for their devotion but for the atmosphere in the temple where the deity is given only a minor share of the liquor that is brought as offering. The rest is distributed among the faithful who ask for it.

Naveen Vyas, 17, a first year student of business administration, was one of those who were trapped. "On my way up here, I could see that many of the youth were reeking of liquor and behaving in a loud and boorish manner," he says. He moved up and entered the narrow path when a part of the barricades collapsed, blocking the way. Devotees began breaking the fences to get into another lane that was largely vacant. In

front, Vyas suffocated and fainted after the barricades crashed into his chest and stomach. He regained consciousness only when rescue operations began. The ground beneath the rescuers' feet was littered with bodies trampled and crushed in the stampede. Later, the dead were all cremated together, as most of them were families.

Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje, who visited the injured in hospital, has announced an inquiry by a retired high court judge into the tragedy and has announced a compensation of Rs 2 lakh each for families of the dead and Rs 50,000 for those injured. State Tourism Minister Usha Punia has urged various religious places to initiate steps for better and safer management of crowds during fairs and festivals.

JOINED IN DEATH: Many families lost all members who were cremated together

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the process, the bamboo shafts interlocked, blocking movement altogether. That was when the power failed. Vyas believes that the breaking barriers loosened the electric wires, plunging the pathway into darkness. Hundreds of pilgrims who were bringing up the rear of the queue, oblivious to the happenings ahead, kept moving forward, building up a crushing pressure on the ones

But for the families of the 154 dead and the 400 injured, such entreaties mean nothing. What they want to know is whether state governments and temple authorities will learn any lessons from the latest tragedy and take steps to ensure that their kith and kin who visit places of worship come back alive. For the moment, all they can do is pray.